EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Did God Give Us Misvot?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:1-2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 3 (Command and Prohibition): the Introduction, Chapter 1 (the categories of mitzvot) and the opening of Chapter 2 (the rational mitzvot) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 9 September 2024, on Zoom (the first shiur after the summer break)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Book So Far

With a few new people in the class, the Rabbi gave an overview.

Rav Saadia wrote Emunot VeDeot **about 1,100 years ago in Iraq**. In his introduction he explains why: he saw people going through life without understanding its purpose, without thinking, and surrounded by conflicting faiths and viewpoints. So he wrote **the very first book of collected Jewish theology**, about 200 years before the Rambam. The Torah, Talmud and Midrash are full of philosophy and theology, but no one before him had set it out in a structured way. "Many of the things the Rambam writes, actually Saadia preceded him."

Section	Content
Introduction	Why he wrote the book; the sources of knowledge
Essay 1	The existence of **a Creator**, as the Rambam later does, before speaking of HaKadosh Baruch Hu. He works through the opposing views, from Plato and Aristotle onward, "not afraid to quote them," and tries to disprove each
Essay 2	Who this Creator is: His **unity**, three chapters against the **Trinity**, and most of all the **anthropomorphisms** in the Torah
Essay 3 (tonight)	**Revelation, mitzvot and the reasons for mitzvot**

The first two essays were very philosophical, because proving a Creator is one of the hardest things to prove or disprove. As Rav Saadia himself conceded, normally we perceive things with our senses and our logic, and here we cannot. Essay 3 has a brief introduction and **ten chapters**.

What Essay 3 will do

Rav Saadia is the first to distinguish between **mitzvot sichliyot**, rational mitzvot that make sense, and mitzvot that are not intuitively rational, though he tries to make even those "as appetising to the intellect" as he can. The Rambam later develops this.

The Rabbi reminded the class of the **Rambam's Shemoneh Perakim**, which they had learned:

- Rational mitzvot: we should develop within ourselves a **desire** to do them, because they are right.
- Mitzvot with no intuitive reason, such as eating non-kosher food: here, as the Chachamim say in the Midrash, it is fine, even praiseworthy, to **want** to do otherwise. You may walk past a non-kosher shop, smell the aromas, and say, "I wish I could enjoy this, but HaKadosh Baruch Hu doesn't allow me."

And he previewed how down-to-earth Rav Saadia's reasons can be. Why did Hashem give us the **festivals**? Because human beings need a break, and because they are a good time for people to gather and for public announcements to be made.

The Introduction: Why Mitzvot at All?

...The author says: before this essay on command and prohibition, I must first introduce **אמר המחבר:**

We have established in the first two essays that HaKadosh Baruch Hu is eternal and created the world alone. Now we must understand that **He created the world only for goodness**.

At the end of Essay 1, Rav Saadia gave three answers to why a Creator would create, and one was that He is benevolent and wishes to bestow goodness. Scripture says so throughout: **טוב ה׳ לכל ורחמיו על כל מעשיו**, "Hashem is good to all, and His mercy is on all His works" (Tehillim 145:9).

Two levels of goodness

1. **Existence itself.** The very fact that Hashem allowed humans to exist is goodness, as Yeshayahu says, **כל הנקרא בשמי ולכבודי בראתיו**, "I created him for My glory."
2. **Thriving.** Not only to exist and survive, but to **succeed and prosper** in that existence. That comes through the **commandments and prohibitions**: **תודיעני ארח חיים שבע שמחות**, "Show me the path of life, fullness of joy" (Tehillim 16:11).

"Wouldn't life be easier without them?"

Then comes the obvious question, "as many of you may be thinking": if the mitzvot are meant to make our life good, wouldn't it be better without them? You can't eat this, you can't do that. Surely Hashem could give us the goodness without all these restrictions and burdens.

Rav Saadia answers:

The good you earn is greater than the good you are given.

Reward for work is far greater than something handed to you as a favour. The Rabbi's example: a person who works hard, succeeds in business and buys his own home, versus one whose parents gifted him the house. "That's lovely and that's great, but it's not the same as: I have worked for this and earned it myself. You can't even compare the two." Hashem wanted us to benefit doubly and properly. As Yeshayahu says, **הנה ה׳ אלהים בחזק יבוא... הנה שכרו אתו ופעלתו לפניו**, "Hashem comes with strength... His reward is with Him and His recompense before Him" (Yeshayahu 40:10). On one hand He wants to give us goodness; on the other, we must earn it.

"Anyone who has studied Derech Hashem with me: basically the whole first section of Derech Hashem of Rabbi Moshe Chaim Luzzatto is summarised in that one paragraph of Saadia Gaon."

"We are the authors of our identity." If someone writes your story for you, that's lovely, but it's not the same as writing your own story and creating your own identity.

Bread of shame

The Ramchal adds another angle that Rav Saadia does not mention: **bread of shame**. When someone is constantly giving to you, there comes a point where it is simply shameful. The Rabbi explained: human relationships need **equilibrium**. When someone does you a favour, you either repay it, or, if you cannot, you give thanks or a present. Someone invites you for Shabbat; you invite them back. "You can't be in a proper relationship where it's always one way." The root of the idea is already here in Rav Saadia: everything worthwhile in life is something we put effort into.

A participant wrote in the chat that in a relationship that cannot be reciprocated, the receiver may avoid the giver, out of shame and inadequacy. "Precisely, thank you," said the Rabbi. Psychology describes how giving too much one way can even lead the receiver to turn on the giver, "because you don't know how to relate to this imbalanced relationship." It is an extreme case, but it happens.

Chapter 1: The Categories of Mitzvot

Rav Saadia opens: we have a body of laws through which to serve HaKadosh Baruch Hu, and we are obligated to keep them, as the Torah says in the next week's parasha (Ki Tavo): **היום הזה ה׳ אלהיך מצוך לעשות את החקים האלה... ושמרת ועשית אותם בכל לבבך**, "This day Hashem your God commands you to do these laws... keep them and do them with all your heart" (Devarim 26:16).

These instructions came with **signs and wonders**: the public revelation at Sinai, which proved their authority, and in response we immediately committed to keeping them. But that alone is not sufficient. It remains our duty to **understand** them, so that we do not do them without understanding. As always with Rav Saadia: first the verse, then the rational explanation.

Four premises of reason

#	What reason dictates
1	**Repay goodness.** When someone does you good, either do good back, if they need it, or, if they do not need it or you cannot, **give thanks**
2	**Do not abuse your benefactor.** Logic does not allow you to curse and abuse someone who has been good to you
3	**Do not harm others.** Within human relationships, we should not cause pain and harm
4	**Work should be rewarded.** If I ask you to work for me, you have given of yourself, and I compensate you

The first great category: the rational mitzvot

The first three premises produce the **rational** mitzvot, in three groups:

Group	Premise	Examples Rav Saadia gives
Thanks to Hashem	We cannot repay Hashem, so we give appreciation and thanksgiving	Prayer, submission, honour and respect in the synagogue, standing in the proper places, revering His name and His Temple
Not abusing Hashem	Not acting against Him, "although of course it makes no difference to God. It's not the way relationships are"	Not believing in another god ("if you have a relationship with one person, you don't bring a third person into it"), not taking His name in vain or swearing falsely, not blaspheming
Not harming one another	**ולא תונו איש את עמיתו**, "do not wrong one another" (Vayikra 25:17)	Telling the truth, pursuing justice, not killing or paining others, not committing adultery or stealing, and **wanting for others what you want for yourself**

"Everything written in the Torah on these, full stop."

Morality is objective

Here the Rabbi drew out a famous philosophical question: **is morality subjective?** For Rav Saadia, absolutely not. Hashem **implanted** in our hearts the recognition of what is good and what is bad. Whatever He commanded, He planted in us an approval of it, and whatever He forbade, a recognition that it is bad, as Mishlei says of wisdom:

> **כי אמת יהגה חכי, ותועבת שפתי רשע** For my palate speaks truth, and wickedness is an abomination to my lips. (Mishlei 8:7)

"I taste it, it's within my palate. I sense it, I feel it."

A participant asked about **caring for the world** we were given, which is a mitzvah early in the Torah, **לעבדה ולשמרה**, "to work it and to guard it." The Rabbi said it could fall under the third group, since harming the environment leaves it worse for other people, or under the first, since it would be ingratitude for what we have been given. "Something which makes total sense."

The second great category: mitzvot reason does not dictate

The fourth premise produces the other category: things that are **not intrinsically good or bad**, but which Hashem made good or bad by commanding them.

The Rabbi cited the famous **Midrash** about the laws of **shechitah**, which require cutting the majority of the windpipe and gullet: does HaKadosh Baruch Hu care whether one cuts a half or a majority? "True, it makes no difference," the Rabbi said. But Hashem wanted to give us more mitzvot, in the mundane parts of life too, **to increase our success**. Rav Saadia quotes:

> **ה׳ חפץ למען צדקו יגדיל תורה ויאדיר** Hashem desired, for the sake of His righteousness, to make the Torah great and glorious. (Yeshayahu 42:21)

Had He not commanded kashrut or the details of shechitah, it would have made no difference. But since He commanded them, doing them is good and refraining is bad. This is like the fourth premise: "If I give you a task, and you didn't fulfil it, that's a problem. I could have not given you any task. I gave you a task, now you need to fulfil it."

The Rabbi stressed that this does not mean "illogical", only that **there is no logic dictating it**. And Rav Saadia adds: even in this category, **with a bit of analysis, we can find some partial benefit**, some small logical reason, just as in the first category we found a great deal.

Summary of Chapter 1

- The purpose of the mitzvot and aveirot is to **bestow goodness**, and earned goodness is the greater good.
- **Rational mitzvot**, implanted within us: (1) honouring Hashem, (2) not abusing Hashem, (3) relationships between people.
- **Commanded mitzvot**: those reason does not dictate, which Hashem added to increase our "workload" and our reward.

So, according to Rav Saadia, every mitzvah in the Torah falls into one of these categories.

A participant asked where Rav Saadia discusses the actual **benefit** of the mitzvot. The Rabbi said that comes in the essay on reward and punishment, together with the question of why the righteous suffer. Here he is only discussing the mitzvot themselves and their purpose.

Do the rational mitzvot apply to everyone?

Chaim asked: God created all people, not only Jews. If these mitzvot are dictated by logic, shouldn't everyone be bound by them? Yet all the examples are from our Torah.

"An excellent question," said the Rabbi. Rav Saadia discusses it later in the book. In short, the **Seven Noachide Laws** capture the essence of this. Interpersonal mitzvot fall under the law of establishing **courts and justice**, creating a fair society. Non-Jews are also commanded not to blaspheme. In the greater framework, the general principles apply to all humanity. Israel has more detail and more mitzvot, "and this is exactly his point: for Israel, He made the Torah great and glorious."

Chapter 2: The Rational Mitzvot Explained

Rav Saadia begins with the easy part, the mitzvot logic dictates, and gives "very basic and simple reasons." He picks four major ones:

1. Murder

If killing were allowed, everyone would end up killing each other. That defeats the very purpose for which Hashem created the world: to bestow goodness, so that people could enjoy it. Causing death or injury takes that away.

2. Adultery

So that humans do not become **like animals**. The Rabbi explained the reason, which he said many Rishonim, the Rambam included, repeat: if a woman could be with more than one man, no one would know the identity of a child's father. (This, he noted, is why the Torah allows a man several wives but not a woman several husbands: paternity remains known.)

Rav Saadia gives the consequences:

- A child would not know **whom to repay** for the good of being born and raised, which ties back to the first premise.

- A father could not **bequeath** an inheritance.
- People could not know their **relatives**, and so could not show the special kindness we naturally feel for family: brothers, cousins, uncles and aunts.

The Rabbi pointed out that Rav Saadia distinguishes between **adultery**, which falls in the rational category, and **incest**, which he places in the other category, to be discussed later. So not all forbidden relations are, for him, dictated by logic.

3. Theft

If theft were allowed, people would rely on stealing for their livelihood and would not **cultivate the world**. The Rabbi expanded: "The way anyone makes money in this world is that you have something to offer which benefits other human beings. Every single job is: I have something to give to someone, and I'm paid for that." If people made their living by stealing, there would be no incentive to make the world better. "This is a basic and simple argument against communism." And everyone would hide whatever they had, and things would disappear.

4. Truth

Truth means describing something as it is. A lie describes it as other than it is. When you are told one thing and then perceive the opposite, it creates conflict within you, what the Rabbi called **cognitive dissonance**. "Truth and falsehood is also sensual." So it is logical that Hashem commands us to keep away from falsehood.

"I'll just do what's good for me"

Some people say nothing is intrinsically wrong. The guiding principle should simply be: I do what brings me pleasure and benefit, and I avoid what harms or worries me.

Rav Saadia says that if you think this, you are a fool, and he will discuss it more in Essay 4. Briefly:

What is "good for you" is equally logical for everyone else. If I hurt my enemy, that brings me satisfaction, so by this logic it is good. But it is bad for him. If I take whatever money or whatever woman I want, it brings me pleasure, but it causes pain to the one I took from. The same act would then be **wisdom and folly at once**, and nothing can be both good and bad at the same time. Society cannot exist like that.

His illustration: **honey with poison in it**. Your principle says eat what is pleasant, so eat the honey, and avoid what harms, so do not eat the poison. Your logic would tell you to eat it and not eat it at the same time, "and that cannot be."

Summary

1. **Essay 3** is about revelation, mitzvot and their reasons. Rav Saadia is the first to distinguish **rational** mitzvot from those reason does not dictate.
2. **Hashem created the world to bestow goodness:** existence first, then thriving through the mitzvot.
3. **Earned good is greater than gifted good**, the seed of the Ramchal's Derech Hashem and his idea of "bread of shame." "We are the authors of our identity."
4. **Four premises of reason:** repay goodness, do not abuse a benefactor, do not harm others, and reward work.

5. **The rational mitzvot:** thanks to Hashem, not abusing Hashem, and not harming people. **Morality is objective**, implanted within us.
6. **The commanded mitzvot:** not intrinsically good or bad, given to "make the Torah great and glorious," and even these have some discoverable benefit.
7. **Chapter 2:** murder destroys the purpose of creation; adultery confuses lineage, gratitude, inheritance and family love; theft removes the incentive to cultivate the world; lies create inner dissonance.
8. **Hedonism fails:** what is good for me is bad for another, and nothing can be both, like honey laced with poison.

Coming Up

- **Next Monday:** the rest of Chapter 2, the mitzvot that are less logical, and on to Chapter 3.
- A participant asked about **killing in war**. Rav Saadia does not discuss war here, and the Rabbi offered to discuss it after the shiur.

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